ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Crowned With Light: Why Tefillin Are Greater Than Sisit

Derech Hashem 4:6:7-9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 7-9 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 10 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Greater than sisit (paragraph 7)

The previous class gave two reasons for sisit: to bring holiness into the mundane, and to wear a kind of collar showing that we are servants of the Almighty. Now the Ramhal turns to tefillin, which he says are far greater than sisit.

The Rabbi gave some reasons we can see this. Sisit are circumstantial: they are only required if you wear a four-cornered garment, whereas tefillin are an obligation. Worn-out sisit can be thrown away, while tefillin go to genizah, because they contain the words of Hashem. And while one may go to the bathroom wearing sisit, one takes tefillin off.

Through tefillin God gives Israel the ability to draw down onto themselves an extension of His light and to be crowned with it. This is what we mean in the morning blessing "who crowns Israel with splendour": the misvah of tefillin. The result is that everything a person does while wearing them has a far greater effect, and "all the nations will see that the name of God is called upon you."

The details matter

The light depends not only on wearing tefillin but on all their laws and details: the boxes must be square, the straps black. "If you wear tefillin with red straps, you're not going to have this light."

The Rabbi highlighted a halachah that is very hard to keep: every moment you wear tefillin you must be conscious of them. You need not keep touching them, but you may not lose awareness that you are wearing these special adornments. The exceptions are the Amidah, "because you're in a different world", and Torah study. Otherwise: "I can't think the same thoughts. I can't speak the way I speak," and certainly not chat to a friend in the synagogue.

Head first, heart second

The two main parts of the human being, his true identity, are the brain and the heart. God arranged that the light first descends on the tefillin of the head, rectifying the brain, and then

spreads to the tefillin of the arm and the heart, and from there the whole body is sanctified.

A participant asked the obvious question: then why put on the arm tefillin first? The Rabbi explained that, as the mekubalim teach, the head tefillin are far greater. (If you could only buy one, buy the head tefillin.) The light of the head is so strong that it needs something ready to descend onto, so the arm tefillin are a preparation. They are a separate misvah with value of their own, but their light is held back until the head tefillin go on.

He then read and translated the LeShem Yihud said before tefillin: the arm, opposite the heart, and the head, opposite the brain, are to subjugate to God "my intellect and the emotions of my heart, from which stem all thoughts and all desires." It need not be recited, but it is important to understand it.

Why not on Shabbat and Yom Tov? (paragraph 8)

We must wear tefillin every day because they are a sign. On holy days we already have this intense connection, and even tefillin on a weekday do not reach the level of Shabbat or Yom Tov. Since the purpose of tefillin is to draw down that light, they are not worn on those days.

This also explains why tefillin and Torah go together: both are direct cleaving to God, which is why there is a practice of learning a little Torah each day in tefillin. Tefillin were once worn all day, and really should be worn all the time; we only avoid the night because one cannot control one's body then. In the past people ploughed their fields in tefillin.

A participant worried that tefillin worn all day might become like the kippah, a reminder no one thinks about any more. Another compared head tefillin to an antenna, and the Rabbi agreed that we receive and draw down through them, while subjugating our thoughts to God. He recalled waiting in tefillin for hours after Shaharit in yeshivah while learning, and said that anyone who can keep focused while learning should wear them.

Hol HaMoed

On Hol HaMoed, the Rabbi explained that the Rishonim spoke only of Shabbat and Yom Tov, and the Rambam wore tefillin on Hol HaMoed. The practice not to wear them comes from the Zohar, and some Rishonim then adopted it. He finds it difficult to neglect a misvah as great as tefillin, but follows the minhag of the last 500 years and does not change it. Many Ashkenazim, especially those of German descent, do wear them; those closer to Hasidut, who follow the Kabbalah, do not.

Muksah on Shabbat (paragraph 9)

A participant asked whether one may wear tefillin on Shabbat or Yom Tov if one wants to. Some Rishonim say no, because it implies that the sign of Shabbat is not strong enough. The halachah is strict, and tefillin on Shabbat are muksah because they have no use that day. But it is the lightest kind of muksah: they may be moved for any need, for example to get at one's tallit. If you find tefillin lying in the street on Shabbat, you should put them on and wear them home, since wearing is not carrying.

Ready to pray

Once a person is adorned with sisit and tefillin, he has signalled that he is God's servant and is bringing down this light. Now he can start to pray and draw down the flow of energy to the whole universe properly.

So one should always try to pray in tefillin. If the choice is between praying with a minyan without tefillin and praying in tefillin without a minyan, it is better to pray in tefillin: "Minyan is a nice auxiliary, but tefillin is essential."

The next class begins the actual order of prayer, starting with the korbanot.

Summary

- Tefillin are greater than sisit: obligatory every day, containing God's words, and crowning Israel with His light.
- The light depends on all the details being correct, and on staying conscious of the tefillin while wearing them.
- The light comes first to the head and spreads to the heart; the arm tefillin go on first as preparation.
- They are not worn on Shabbat and Yom Tov, which already give that connection; on Shabbat they are muksah, though of the lightest kind.
- Tefillin prepare a person to pray, and praying in tefillin comes before praying with a minyan.

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